

Freyd Mitchell Embedding Theorem

Zih-Yu Hsieh

May 11, 2026

The goal is to understand the way of embedding any small Abelian Category into the category of abelian groups $\mathbf{Ab}$, or even stronger, into the category of R -modules over some (not necessarily commutative) ring R .

1 Abelian Category

1.1 Basic Structure of Abelian Category

There are multiple ways of defining Abelian Category, here chose the definition used in the book.

First, let $\mathcal{A}$ be a category with a zero object (an object that's both initial and final), denoted as $\mathbf{0}$. We first put on the notion of kernel and cokernel:

Definition 1. Given $A, B \in \mathcal{A}$ two objects, a **zero morphism from A to B** is the unique morphism obtained by the composition $0 : A \rightarrow \mathbf{0} \rightarrow B$.

Let $\phi : A \rightarrow B$ be a morphism in $\mathcal{A}$, a morphism $\ker(\phi) : K \rightarrow A$ is a **kernel of ϕ** , if $\phi \circ \ker(\phi) = 0$, and for every morphism $f : K' \rightarrow A$ satisfying $\phi \circ f = 0$, there exists a unique morphism $f' : K' \rightarrow K$, such that $f = \ker(\phi) \circ f'$. Namely, the following diagram commutes:

$$\begin{array}{ccccc} K & \xrightarrow{\ker(\phi)} & A & \xrightarrow{\phi} & B \\ \uparrow \exists! f' & \nearrow f & & \searrow 0 & \\ K' & & & & \end{array}$$

Similarly, a morphism $\operatorname{coker}(\phi) : B \rightarrow C$ is a **cokernel of ϕ** , if $\operatorname{coker}(\phi) \circ \phi = 0$, and for every morphism $g : B \rightarrow C'$ satisfying $g \circ \phi = 0$, there exists a unique morphism $g' : C \rightarrow C'$, such that $g = g' \circ \operatorname{coker}(\phi)$. Namely, the following diagram commutes:

$$\begin{array}{ccccc} A & \xrightarrow{\phi} & B & \xrightarrow{\operatorname{coker}(\phi)} & C \\ & \searrow 0 & \searrow g & \downarrow \exists! g' & \\ & & & C' & \end{array}$$

Which, the composition of any morphism with the zero morphism is a zero morphism (as the morphism through $\mathbf{0}$ from/to any object must be unique). Also, the universality above guarantees kernels and cokernels to be isomorphic. Notice that kernels and cokernels under this definitions, are monomorphisms and epimorphisms respectively:

Proposition 1. *All kernels are monomorphisms, and all cokernels are epimorphisms.*

Proof. Let $\phi : A \rightarrow B$ be a morphism, $k : K \rightarrow A$ denotes its kernel, and $c : B \rightarrow C$ denotes its cokernel.

First, for kernel, choose two morphisms $f_0, f_1 : K' \rightarrow K$ such that $h = k \circ f_0 = k \circ f_1 : K' \rightarrow A$. Then, since $\phi \circ h = (\phi \circ k) \circ f_0 = 0 \circ f_0 = 0$, the universality guarantees a unique morphism $f' : K' \rightarrow K$, such that $h = \ker(\phi) \circ f'$. Since f_0, f_1 in the position in f' satisfies the given equality, the uniqueness of f' guarantees $f_0 = f_1 = f'$.

For cokernel, given $g_0, g_1 : C \rightarrow C'$ such that $\ell = g_0 \circ c = g_1 \circ c : B \rightarrow C'$, as $\ell \circ \phi = g_0 \circ (c \circ \phi) = g_0 \circ 0 = 0$, similar argument on universality guarantees $g_0 = g_1$. $\square$

With this property, kernels and cokernels can be viewed as subobject / quotient objects of certain morphisms.

Now, here is the definition of Abelian Category:

Definition 2. *A category $\mathcal{A}$ is an **Abelian Category**, if it satisfies the following axioms:*

- A0. $\mathcal{A}$ has a zero object $\mathbf{0}$, which serves as both initial and final object.*
- A1. Finite product and coproduct exists. (also called “direct product” and “direct sum”).*
- A2. Every morphism has a kernel and a cokernel.*
- A3. Every monomorphism is a kernel of some morphism, and every epimorphism is a cokernel of a morphism.*

With this definition, we can immediately conclude the following:

Proposition 2. *Let $\phi : A \rightarrow B$ be a morphism. Then:*

- 1. If ϕ is a monomorphism, then $\mathbf{0} \rightarrow A$ is its kernel.*
- 2. Similarly, if ϕ is an epimorphism, then $B \rightarrow \mathbf{0}$ is its cokernel.*

Proof.

- 1. It's clear that $\mathbf{0} \rightarrow A \xrightarrow{\phi} B$ is zero morphism. Now, suppose $f : K' \rightarrow A$ satisfies $\phi \circ f = 0 : K' \rightarrow B$, then since $0 : K \rightarrow A$ satisfies $\phi \circ 0 = 0 : K' \rightarrow A$ also, the monomorphism property guarantees $f = 0$. Hence, we have $K \xrightarrow{f} A = K \rightarrow \mathbf{0} \rightarrow A$ the zero morphism, showing f uniquely factors through $\mathbf{0} \rightarrow A$ (as the morphism $K \rightarrow \mathbf{0}$ is unique).
- 2. Again, it's clear that $A \xrightarrow{\phi} B \rightarrow \mathbf{0}$ is zero. Now, suppose $g : B \rightarrow C'$ satisfies $g \circ \phi = 0 : A \rightarrow C'$, again $0 : B \rightarrow C'$ satisfies $0 \circ \phi = 0 : A \rightarrow C'$, showing $g = 0$ using the epimorphism property. So, $B \xrightarrow{g} C' = B \rightarrow \mathbf{0} \rightarrow C'$ is the zero morphism, showing g uniquely factors through $B \rightarrow \mathbf{0}$.

□

Of course, for the most generality, we also have the following properties for any two objects $A, B \in \mathcal{A}$:

- Finite direct sum and direct product coincides, so $A \oplus B$ is a biproduct. Let ι, π denote inclusion / projection respectively, then we require $\pi_j \circ \iota_j = 1_j$ for $j = A, B$, and π_i, ι_j be cokernel / kernel (resp.) for each other if $i \neq j$.
- The homset $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(A, B)$ has a natural abelian group structure, with $0 : A \rightarrow B$ serves as the identity.

In some literature (for instance, Aluffi), the second property is assumed, and can be used to prove the first property (in fact, the first property is true for general additive category).

Conversely, some literature assumes the first property, and use it to show the second property (for instance, the book of the reference). Here, we'll assume this, and show the abelian group structure on the homsets.

Notation: We'll use $\iota_A : A \rightarrow A \oplus B$, $\iota_B : B \rightarrow A \oplus B$ to denote the canonical inclusion for coproduct, and $\pi_A : A \oplus B \rightarrow A$, $\pi_B : A \oplus B \rightarrow B$ to denote the canonical projection for product.

Also, given two morphisms $f_A : C \rightarrow A$, $f_B : C \rightarrow B$, denote the product morphism as $\begin{pmatrix} f_A \\ f_B \end{pmatrix} : C \rightarrow A \oplus B$ (so $\pi_A \circ \begin{pmatrix} f_A \\ f_B \end{pmatrix} = f_A$, and $\pi_B \circ \begin{pmatrix} f_A \\ f_B \end{pmatrix} = f_B$). Similarly, given two morphisms $g_A : A \rightarrow D$, $g_B : B \rightarrow D$, denote the coproduct morphism as $(g_A \ g_B) : A \oplus B \rightarrow D$ (so $(g_A \ g_B) \circ \iota_A = g_A$, and $(g_A \ g_B) \circ \iota_B = g_B$).

This is similar to the matrix notation. In general, given objects $A, B, C, D \in \mathcal{A}$, with morphisms $f : A \rightarrow C$, $g : A \rightarrow D$, $h : B \rightarrow C$, and $\ell : B \rightarrow D$, we have morphisms $\begin{pmatrix} f \\ g \end{pmatrix} : A \rightarrow C \oplus D$ and $\begin{pmatrix} h \\ \ell \end{pmatrix} : B \rightarrow C \oplus D$.

Which, they gathered into a morphism $s = \begin{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} f \\ g \end{pmatrix} \\ \begin{pmatrix} h \\ \ell \end{pmatrix} \end{pmatrix} : A \oplus B \rightarrow C \oplus D$.

Similarly, we can define morphisms $(f \ h) : A \oplus B \rightarrow C$ and $(g \ \ell) : A \oplus B \rightarrow D$, which further gathered into a morphism $s' = \begin{pmatrix} (f \ h) \\ (g \ \ell) \end{pmatrix} : A \oplus B \rightarrow C \oplus D$.

Notice that $s = s'$, because we have the following four equalities:

$$\pi_C \circ (s \circ \iota_A) = \pi_C \circ \begin{pmatrix} f \\ g \end{pmatrix} = f = (f \ h) \circ \iota_A = (\pi_C \circ s') \circ \iota_A \quad (1)$$

$$\pi_D \circ (s \circ \iota_A) = \pi_D \circ \begin{pmatrix} f \\ g \end{pmatrix} = g = (g \ \ell) \circ \iota_A = (\pi_D \circ s') \circ \iota_A \quad (2)$$

$$\pi_C \circ (s \circ \iota_B) = \pi_C \circ \begin{pmatrix} h \\ \ell \end{pmatrix} = h = (f \ h) \circ \iota_B = (\pi_C \circ s') \circ \iota_B \quad (3)$$

$$\pi_D \circ (s \circ \iota_B) = \pi_D \circ \begin{pmatrix} h \\ \ell \end{pmatrix} = \ell = (g \ \ell) \circ \iota_B = (\pi_D \circ s') \circ \iota_B \quad (4)$$

Which, (1) and (2) state that $s \circ \iota_A = s' \circ \iota_A$ (as their projection onto C and D agrees, so universality of product forces them to be the same); similarly, (3) and (4) state that $s \circ \iota_B = s' \circ \iota_B$ using product property again.

Finally, the two formula regarding the inclusions ι_A, ι_B precisely force $s = s'$ using the coproduct property. So, there's no ambiguity about the order. Which, we'll denote $s = s' = \begin{pmatrix} f & h \\ g & \ell \end{pmatrix}$.

Now, we'll define the “addition” on homsets:

Definition 3. Let $f, g \in \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(A, B)$, we define the morphism $f + g \in \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(A, B)$ to be the following:

$$A \xrightarrow{\begin{pmatrix} 1_A \\ 1_A \end{pmatrix}} A \oplus A \xrightarrow{(f \ g)} B$$

Another definition is the following:

$$A \xrightarrow{\begin{pmatrix} f \\ g \end{pmatrix}} B \oplus B \xrightarrow{(1_B \ 1_B)} B$$

Notice the two actually define the same morphism:

Proof. Consider the morphism $m = \begin{pmatrix} f & 0 \\ 0 & g \end{pmatrix} : A \oplus A \rightarrow B \oplus B$, then we have the following:

$$(1_B \ 1_B) \circ m = \tag{5}$$

□

Include: Additive structure on homsets, characterization of direct sums, definition of image / coimage, exactness (and some characterization about image=kernel, coimage=cokernel, and other compositions), subobject, intersection and union.

The goal for this section is establishing some utilities needed for embedding.

Let's first define additive functor:

Definition 4. Let $\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{B}$ be two Abelian Categories. Let $F : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathcal{B}$ be a functor.

F is **additive**, if for any two objects $A, B \in \mathcal{A}$, the map $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(A, B) \rightarrow \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{B}}(F(A), F(B))$ is a group homomorphism with respect to the group structure on each homset.

For instance, $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(A, -) : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathbf{Ab}$ and $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(-, A) : \mathcal{A}^{\text{op}} \rightarrow \mathbf{Ab}$ are additive functors, as composition of morphisms respect the additive structure.

Here is a characterization of additive functors:

Theorem 1. A functor between abelian categories is additive $\iff$ it maps direct sums to direct sums, i.e. $F(A \oplus B) \cong F(A) \oplus F(B)$, with the agreement on inclusions / projections.

Proof. This requires the characterization of direct sum: Given $A \oplus B$, then $\pi_j \circ \iota_j = 1_j$ on each $j = A, B$, while $\iota_A \circ \pi_A + \iota_B \circ \pi_B = 1$ on $A \oplus B$.

$\implies$: Suppose F is additive. Given $F\pi_j \circ F\iota_j = F(\pi_j \circ \iota_j) = 1_{F(j)}$ for $j = A, B$, and $1 = F(1) = F(\iota_A \circ \pi_A + \iota_B \circ \pi_B) = F\iota_A \circ F\pi_A + F\iota_B \circ F\pi_B$, showing $F(A \oplus B)$ with $F\iota_A, F\iota_B, F\pi_A, F\pi_B$ form a direct sum system for $F(A), F(B)$, hence $F(A \oplus B) \cong F(A) \oplus F(B)$.

$\impliedby$: Suppose F maps direct sum to direct sum, then for every $f, g \in \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(A, B)$, we have $f + g : A \rightarrow B$ being the following:

$$A \xrightarrow{f+g} B = A \xrightarrow{\begin{pmatrix} 1_A \\ 1_A \end{pmatrix}} A \oplus A \xrightarrow{(f \ g)} B \quad (6)$$

Apply the functor, we get:

$$F(A) \xrightarrow{F(f+g)} F(B) = F(A) \xrightarrow{F\begin{pmatrix} 1_A \\ 1_A \end{pmatrix}} F(A \oplus A) \xrightarrow{F(f \ g)} F(B) \quad (7)$$

$$= F(A) \xrightarrow{\begin{pmatrix} 1_{F(A)} \\ 1_{F(A)} \end{pmatrix}} F(A \oplus A) \xrightarrow{(Ff \ Fg)} F(B) \quad (8)$$

$$= F(A) \xrightarrow{Ff+Fg} F(B) \quad (9)$$

Note: Since both projection $F\pi_A : F(A \oplus A) \rightarrow F(A)$ satisfy $F\pi_A \circ F\begin{pmatrix} 1_A \\ 1_A \end{pmatrix} = F(\pi_A \circ \begin{pmatrix} 1_A \\ 1_A \end{pmatrix}) = F1_A = 1_{F(A)}$, and $F\pi_A$ are the projections of $F(A \oplus A) \cong F(A) \oplus F(A)$ (as F respects direct sum), then $F\begin{pmatrix} 1_A \\ 1_A \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 1_{F(A)} \\ 1_{F(A)} \end{pmatrix}$. Apply similar logic to $F(f \ g)$ we get the same.

So, $F(f + g) = Ff + Fg$, hence F is additive.

□

As a result, we have the following:

Corollary 1. *A left / right exact functor between Abelian Categories is additive.*

Proof. Because the identity relations on inclusion / projections are preserved by any functor, so $F\pi_i \circ F\iota_i = F(\pi_i \circ \iota_i) = F(1_i) = 1_{F(i)}$ given $i = A, B$.

Also, left / right exact functor preserves either kernel or cokernel. For definiteness, if F is left exact, then for $i \neq j$, we have $F\iota_i$ remains as kernel of $F\pi_j$; then, the identity relations guarantee $F\pi_j$ to be epimorphism, hence a cokernel of $F\iota_i$ (which is a kernel). (For right exact functor, it preserves cokernel instead, so swap the proof to $F\pi_j$ works just fine).

By the characterization of direct sum, left / right exact functor preserves direct sum system, hence is additive. □

1.2 Tools for Embedding

Now, let's define the concept of embedding:

Definition 5. Let $F : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathcal{B}$ be an additive functor. F is **faithful**, if the homomorphism $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(A, B) \rightarrow \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{B}}(F(A), F(B))$ is injective. In this case, F is called an **embedding**. If F is an exact functor, it's called an **exact embedding**.

Which, embeddings have a nice notion of “preserving commutativity” and “non-exactness”:

Proposition 3. Let $F : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathcal{B}$ be an additive functor. Then, TFAE:

- (a) F is an embedding.
- (b) F carries non-commutative diagrams into non-commutative diagrams.
- (c) F carries non-exact sequences to non-exact sequences.

As a consequence, an exact embedding have commutativity / exactness of diagrams in $\mathcal{A}$ and commutativity / exactness of their images in $\mathcal{B}$ being equivalent.

Now, we wish to achieve an embedding of Abelian categories that preserves exactness. Here comes a definition:

Definition 6. An abelian category $\mathcal{A}$ is **very Abelian**, if every small exact subcategory $\mathcal{B} \subset \mathcal{A}$ has an exact embedding $\mathcal{B} \rightarrow \mathbf{Ab}$.
On the other hand, $\mathcal{A}$ is **fully Abelian** if every full small exact subcategory $\overline{\mathcal{A}} \subset \mathcal{A}$ has a ring R and a full exact embedding of $\overline{\mathcal{A}}$ into $R - \text{Mod}$.

The main goal of embedding is applying statements that're true in $\mathbf{Ab}$ to any very Abelian categories. For this to be applicable to arbitrary objects / morphisms in arbitrary Abelian category, we first require any collection of objects / morphisms to be contained in an exact category:

Proposition 4. Given any set $\{A_i\}_i$ of objects in an Abelian category $\mathcal{A}$, there is a full small exact subcategory $\overline{\mathcal{A}} \subset \mathcal{A}$, such that $A_i \in \overline{\mathcal{A}}$ for all i .

Proof. Let $\mathcal{A}^0$ be a full small subcategory containing $\{A_i\}_i$.

Let $\mathcal{A}^1$ be a full subcategory that contains all the kernels / cokernels (as fixed objects) of morphisms in $\mathcal{A}^0$, and also finite direct sums of objects in $\mathcal{A}^0$. Since $\mathcal{A}^0$ is small, all of the mentioned objects collect to a set, and hence $\mathcal{A}^1$ is a full small subcategory.

Inductively, let $\mathcal{A}^{n+1}$ be the full subcategory generated based on the kernels / cokernels / finite direct sums in $\mathcal{A}^n$. Then, based on same reasoning as above, $\mathcal{A}^{n+1}$ is also small.

Finally, considering $\overline{\mathcal{A}} := \bigcup_{i \geq 0} \mathcal{A}^i$, then it's a full subcategory (as the chain $\mathcal{A}^0 \subset \mathcal{A}^1 \subset \dots$ has each subcategory being full). It's an Abelian category, because take any isomorphism (for instance, 1_A for $A \in \mathcal{A}^0$) it has kernel / cokernel being 0; all morphism ϕ is contained in some $\mathcal{A}^i$, hence has kernels / cokernels in $\mathcal{A}^{i+1}$; and, all finite direct sums exists. So, we obtain a full small subcategory that's Abelian, and contains all $\{A_i\}_i$. $\square$

With this notion, the category can be more controlled in the following sense:

Definition 7. A category is **well-powered**, if the family of subobjects (i.e. equivalence classes of monomorphisms $A' \hookrightarrow A$, where the equivalence are stated by isomorphisms on A' that commutes with the monomorphisms) forms a set.

Proposition 5. An Abelian Category that has a generator is well-powered.

Proof. Let $G \in \mathcal{A}$ be a generator, and $A \in \mathcal{A}$ be any object. Then, given a nontrivial subobject $\iota : A' \hookrightarrow A$, the map $\iota \circ - : \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A') \rightarrow \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A)$ is injective.

Hence, given A' a subobject of A , it can be associated to a subgroup of $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A)$ (namely the image of $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A')$ under $\iota \circ -$).

This is well-defined, as if $\iota_1 : A'_1 \hookrightarrow A$ and $\iota_2 : A'_2 \hookrightarrow A$ are two isomorphic subobjects, there exists isomorphism $\phi : A'_1 \xrightarrow{\sim} A'_2$ such that $\iota_1 = \iota_2 \circ \phi$. Hence, for any $f \in \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A'_1)$, $\iota_1 \circ f = \iota_2 \circ (\phi \circ f)$ (with $\phi \circ f \in \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A'_2)$), and conversely all $g \in \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A'_2)$ satisfies $\iota_2 \circ g = \iota_1 \circ (\phi^{-1} \circ g)$ (with $\phi^{-1} \circ g \in \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A'_1)$). This shows that $\iota_1 \circ -$ and $\iota_2 \circ -$ have the same set image, hence isomorphic subobject corresponds to the same subgroup in $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A)$.

Finally, any two non-isomorphic subobject can't have the same subgroup in $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A)$ □

2 Special Case - Mitchell's Embedding Theorem:

This is a special case of the general embedding theorem. We'll first introduce some notions relevant to the proof.

Over $R - \text{Mod}$ (category of left / right R -modules) for some ring R , there are definitions of projective modules P over R , namely when $\text{Hom}_R(P, -) : R - \text{Mod} \rightarrow \mathbf{Ab}$ is an exact functor.

(As a side note, take $P := R$ then it becomes a forgetful functor, as one can prove that $\text{Hom}_R(R, M) \cong M$ as abelian groups; if R is commutative, then the isomorphism is true as R -modules).

Now, here's the generalization to arbitrary Abelian category:

Definition 8. An object $P \in \mathcal{A}$ is **projective**, if the functor $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P, -) : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathbf{Ab}$ is exact.

Equivalently, given any epimorphism $f : A \twoheadrightarrow B$, the post composition map $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P, A) \xrightarrow{f \circ -} \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P, B)$ is surjective. It's equivalent to the following:

Given any morphism $p : P \rightarrow B$, there exists $p' : P \rightarrow A$, such that $p = f \circ p'$, or the following diagram commutes:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} P & & \\ \exists p' \downarrow & \searrow p & \\ A & \xrightarrow{f} & B \end{array}$$

Which, it has the following property:

Proposition 6. Let $\{P_i\}_i$ be a family of projective objects in $\mathcal{A}$, if their direct sum $\bigoplus_i P_i$ exists, then it's also projective.

Proof. Let $f : A \twoheadrightarrow B$ be an epimorphism, and $(p_i)_i : \bigoplus_i P_i \rightarrow B$ a morphism. Then, composing with each inclusion, we have $(p_i)_i \circ \iota_j = p_j : P_j \rightarrow B$ for all index j .

The individual projectiveness guarantees a morphism $p'_j : P_j \rightarrow A$ such that $p_j = f \circ p'_j$, hence the direct sum property gathers them into a morphism $(p'_i)_i : \bigoplus_i P_i \rightarrow A$, such that $(p'_i)_i \circ \iota_j = p'_j$ for all index j .

Finally, notice that $f \circ (p'_i)_i = (p_i)_i$: Precomposing with all inclusions, we get $f \circ (p'_i)_i \circ \iota_j = f \circ p'_j = p_j = (p_i)_i \circ \iota_j$. Hence, the coproduct property guarantees the two to be the same. This shows the projectiveness of $\bigoplus_i P_i$. $\square$

We also need the notion of generator of a category:

Definition 9. An object $G \in \mathcal{A}$ is a **generator**, if the functor $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, -) : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathbf{Ab}$ is an embedding.

Here are some characterization of generators:

Proposition 7. TFAE:

1. G is a generator.

2. For every nonzero $f : A \rightarrow B$, there exists $g : G \rightarrow A$, such that $f \circ g : G \rightarrow A \rightarrow B$ is nonzero.
3. Let $\iota : A' \hookrightarrow A$ be a proper subobject, there exists a morphism $g : G \rightarrow A$, such that $\text{im}(g)$ is not a subobject of A' (i.e. there doesn't exist a monomorphism $i : \text{im}(g) \hookrightarrow A'$, such that $\text{im}(g) \hookrightarrow A = \text{im}(g) \xrightarrow{i} A' \xrightarrow{\iota} A$).

Proof.

1 $\iff$ 2: Here, G is a generator $\iff$ the map $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(A, B) \rightarrow \text{Hom}_{\mathbf{Ab}}(\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A), \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, B))$ by $f \mapsto (f \circ -)$ is injective for all object A, B .

Hence, given G is a generator, every nonzero $f : A \rightarrow B$ has $f \circ - : \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A) \rightarrow \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, B)$ being nonzero, there exists $g \in \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A)$ where $f \circ g \neq 0$.

Conversely, if the second condition is true, then the map $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(A, B) \rightarrow \text{Hom}_{\mathbf{Ab}}(\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, A), \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, B))$ by $f \mapsto (f \circ -)$ is injective (as $f \neq 0$ implies $f \circ - \neq 0$), hence $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(G, -)$ is an embedding.

2 $\implies$ 3: Suppose all nonzero $f : A \rightarrow B$ has some $g : G \rightarrow A$, such that $f \circ g : G \rightarrow A \rightarrow B$ is nonzero. Let $\iota : A' \hookrightarrow A$ be a proper subobject, then its cokernel $c : A \twoheadrightarrow C$ is nonzero. Hence, there exists morphism $g : G \rightarrow A$, such that $c \circ g : G \rightarrow A \twoheadrightarrow C$ is nonzero.

As ι is also a kernel of c (since it's monic), with $c \circ g \neq 0$, g doesn't factor through ι , hence its image is not a subobject of A' .

2 $\Leftarrow$ 3: If condition 3 holds, for any nonzero $f : A \rightarrow B$, its kernel $k : K \hookrightarrow A$ is a proper subobject. Hence, there exists $g : G \rightarrow A$, such that its image isn't a subobject of K (equivalently, g doesn't factor through k). As a result, $f \circ g \neq 0$ (as if $f \circ g = 0$, then g must factor through k , which contradicts).

□

Here is one of the key tools for the special case of the embedding theorem - the projective generators:

Lemma 1. *If P is projective, then P is a generator $\iff \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P, A)$ is nontrivial for all $A \not\cong 0$.*

Proof.

$\implies$: Suppose P is a generator, then for any $A \not\cong 0$, because identity $1_A : A \xrightarrow{\sim} A$ is nonzero, then the map $1_A \circ - : \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P, A) \rightarrow \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P, A)$ is nonzero. Hence, there exists $g \in \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P, A)$ such that $1_A \circ g = g \neq 0$, showing $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P, A) \neq 0$.

$\Leftarrow$: Suppose $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P, A)$ is nontrivial for all $A \not\cong 0$. Here, we use the second condition above for generators: Given nonzero $f : A \rightarrow B$, consider the coimage of f , say $c : A \twoheadrightarrow C$ (hence, there exists monomorphism $\bar{f} : C \hookrightarrow B$, such that $f = \bar{f} \circ c$). This forces $c \neq 0$, hence $C \not\cong 0$, in particular $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P, C) \neq 0$. So, there exists nontrivial $p : P \rightarrow C$.

Now, using the projectiveness of P , there exists $p' : P \rightarrow A$, such that $p = c \circ p'$ (which, $p' \neq 0$ because $p \neq 0$). Then, we have $f \circ p' = \bar{f} \circ (c \circ p') = \bar{f} \circ p$. Finally, since $\bar{f}$ is a monomorphism, then $p \neq 0$ implies $\bar{f} \circ p \neq 0$, hence $f \circ p' \neq 0$.

So, the second condition for generator is satisfied, showing P is a generator.

□

Which, we end up with the following property of projective generators:

Lemma 2. *Suppose $\{P_i\}_i$ are projective, and one of P_j is a generator, then if arbitrary direct sum $\bigoplus_i P_i$ exists, it's also a projective generator.*

Proof. From **Proposition 4**, we know the direct sum is projective; from **Lemma 1**, we know it's a generator iff all nonzero object has homsets from direct sum being nontrivial.

Which, for any nonzero object $A \in \mathcal{A}$, consider the following isomorphism using universality of direct sum:

$$\mathrm{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(\bigoplus_i P_i, A) \cong \bigoplus_i \mathrm{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P_i, A) \quad (10)$$

Because one P_j is a generator, $\mathrm{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P_j, A)$ is nontrivial, then the above homset is also nontrivial, showing $\bigoplus_i P_i$ is a generator. □

Now, let's state the theorem:

Theorem 2. (Mitchell)

An Abelian category $\mathcal{A}$ with a projective generator is very Abelian. Moreover, if $\mathcal{A}$ is bicomplete, it's fully Abelian.

Proof. Here, the very Abelian part follows from the fact that $\text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P, -)$ is an exact abedding to $\mathbf{Ab}$ by definition. We'll focus on the fully Abelian part.

Let $\mathcal{A}'$ be a full small exact subcategory of $\mathcal{A}$, and P a projective generator for $\mathcal{A}$. For any $A \in \mathcal{A}'$, let $(P, A) := \text{Hom}_{\mathcal{A}}(P, A)$.

We'll first construct a projective generator that has an epimorphism to each $A \in \mathcal{A}'$.

Use (P, A) to define the following morphism:

$$c_A : P_A := \bigoplus_{\phi \in (P, A)} P \rightarrow A \quad (11)$$

Where, if $\iota_\psi : P \hookrightarrow P_A$ denotes the inclusion corresponding to the index $\psi \in (P, A)$, then $c_A \circ \iota_\psi = \psi$.

Notice that P_A is a projective generator by **Lemma 2**; also, notice further that c_A is in fact an epimorphism: Given any morphism $f : A \rightarrow B$ such that $f \circ c_A = 0$, then any $\psi \in (P, A)$ satisfies $f \circ \psi = f \circ c_A \circ \iota_\psi = 0$, showing the morphism $f \circ - : (P_A, A) \rightarrow (P_A, B) = 0$. If consider its cokernel $1_B \circ - : (P, B) \xrightarrow{\sim} (P, B)$ (Note: zero morphism has cokernel being identity), using the fact that $(P_A, -)$ is an exact embedding (by projective generator property), we retrieve that 1_B is the cokernel of f in $\mathcal{A}$ (using **Proposition 3**), hence $f = 0$.

Then, consider the direct sum $\bar{P} := \bigoplus_{A \in \mathcal{A}'} P_A$, it's still a projective generator by **Lemma 2** again, while any $B \in \mathcal{A}'$ there is an epimorphism $\bar{c}_B : \bar{P} \twoheadrightarrow B$ defined by direct sum of morphisms $c_B : P_B \twoheadrightarrow B$ and $0 : P_A \rightarrow B$ for any $A \neq B$ ($\bar{c}_B$ is an epimorphism, because given $\iota_B : P_B \hookrightarrow \bar{P}$ as inclusion, $\bar{c}_B \circ \iota_B = c_B$ is an epimorphism). Hence, $\bar{P}$ is a projective generator of $\mathcal{A}$, while every $A \in \mathcal{A}'$ it has an epimorphism $\bar{c}_A : \bar{P} \twoheadrightarrow A$.

Now, let's consider the ring $R := \text{End}_{\mathcal{A}}(\bar{P})$. Notice for any $A \in \mathcal{A}'$, the homset $(\bar{P}, A)$ is a canonical R -module by pre-composition (it's a left R -module if consider diagrammatically; it's a right R -module if consider classical notation of composition). In particular, for any $r \in R := \text{End}_{\mathcal{A}}(\bar{P})$, the action on $\phi \in (P, A)$ is as:

$$\phi \cdot r := \phi \circ r : \bar{P} \xrightarrow{r} \bar{P} \xrightarrow{\phi} A \quad (12)$$

The module structure is guaranteed by the additive structure / $\mathbb{Z}$ -bilinearity of composition.

Also, given any morphism $f : A \rightarrow B$, the canonical post-composition morphism $f \circ - : (P, A) \rightarrow (P, B)$ is an R -module homomorphism by associativity of composition:

$$f \circ (\phi \dot{r}) = f \circ (\phi \circ r) = (f \circ \phi) \circ r = (f \circ \phi) \dot{r} \quad (13)$$

Hence, this defines $(\bar{P}, -) : \mathcal{A}' \rightarrow R\text{-Mod}$ as an exact embedding.

Finally, to check it's fully Abelian, it remains to verify $(\bar{P}, -)$ is a full functor. Which, given any $A, B \in \mathcal{A}'$ and $\bar{f} : (\bar{P}, A) \rightarrow (\bar{P}, B)$ in $R\text{-Mod}$, we wish to find $f : A \rightarrow B$ in $\mathcal{A}'$, satisfying $\bar{f} = f \circ - : (\bar{P}, A) \rightarrow (\bar{P}, B)$.

Here, we use the fact that $\bar{c}_A : \bar{P} \twoheadrightarrow A$ is an epimorphism. Consider $k : K \rightarrow \bar{P}$ as the kernel of $\bar{c}_A$, we have the following exact sequence in $\mathcal{A}'$:

$$0 \rightarrow K \xrightarrow{k} \bar{P} \xrightarrow{\bar{c}_A} A \rightarrow 0 \quad (14)$$

Then, applying the embedding $(\bar{P}, -)$, we get the following commutative diagram (with the two rows being exact):

$$\begin{array}{ccccccc} 0 & \longrightarrow & (\bar{P}, K) & \xrightarrow{k \circ -} & (\bar{P}, \bar{P}) = R & \xrightarrow{\bar{c}_A \circ -} & (\bar{P}, A) \longrightarrow 0 \\ & & \downarrow \exists g & & \downarrow \bar{f} & & \\ & & (\bar{P}, \bar{P}) = R & \xrightarrow{\bar{c}_B \circ -} & (\bar{P}, B) & \longrightarrow & 0 \end{array}$$

Recall that R is projective within $\mathbf{R-Mod}$, hence given epimorphism $\bar{c}_B \circ - : R \twoheadrightarrow (\bar{P}, B)$, and $\bar{f} \circ (\bar{c}_A \circ -) : R \rightarrow (\bar{P}, B)$, there exists $g : R \rightarrow R$ for the above commutative diagram to commute.

Then, since R as an R -module has the morphism g solely determined by $g(1)$ (in particular, the map g is defined by $r \mapsto g(1) \cdot r := g(1) \circ r$). Hence, take $h := g(1) \in (\bar{P}, \bar{P}) = R$, the map $g = h \circ - : R \rightarrow R$.

Now, going back to $\mathcal{A}'$, notice we have the following commutative diagram:

$$\begin{array}{ccccccc} 0 & \longrightarrow & K & \xrightarrow{k} & \bar{P} & \xrightarrow{\bar{c}_A} & A \longrightarrow 0 \\ & & & & \downarrow h & & \\ & & & & \bar{P} & \xrightarrow{\bar{c}_B} & B \longrightarrow 0 \end{array}$$

Notice that $(\bar{c}_B \circ h) \circ k = 0$: Using **Proposition 3**, after applying the embedding we have the following equality on morphisms:

$$((\bar{c}_B \circ -) \circ g) \circ (k \circ -) = \bar{f} \circ ((\bar{c}_A \circ -) \circ (k \circ -)) = \bar{f} \circ (\bar{c}_A \circ k \circ -) = 0 \quad (15)$$

(Note: Recall that k is the kernel of $\bar{c}_A$).

Then, since $g = h \circ -$, the embedded morphism of $(\bar{c}_B \circ h) \circ k$ is precisely $((\bar{c}_B \circ -) \circ g) \circ (k \circ -) = 0$, then the proposition guarantees the morphism before applying the embedding is also 0.

Hence, as $\bar{c}_A$ is an epimorphism, it's also the cokernel of k , showing there exists unique $f : A \rightarrow B$, such that $\bar{c}_B \circ h = f \circ \bar{c}_A$:

$$\begin{array}{ccccccc} 0 & \longrightarrow & K & \xrightarrow{k} & \bar{P} & \xrightarrow{\bar{c}_A} & A \longrightarrow 0 \\ & & & & \downarrow h & & \downarrow \exists! f \\ & & & & \bar{P} & \xrightarrow{\bar{c}_B} & B \longrightarrow 0 \end{array}$$

Now, apply the embedding to the square above, we get the following commutative diagram in $\mathbf{R-Mod}$:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} (\bar{P}, \bar{P}) = R & \xrightarrow{\bar{c}_A \circ -} & (\bar{P}, A) \\ h \circ - = g \downarrow & & \downarrow f \circ - \\ (\bar{P}, \bar{P}) = R & \xrightarrow{\bar{c}_B \circ -} & (\bar{P}, B) \end{array}$$

Notice that in one of the above diagrams, replacing $f \circ -$ using $\bar{f}$ have the same diagram commute, hence we get the equality:

$$(f \circ -) \circ (\bar{c}_A \circ -) = (\bar{c}_B \circ -) \circ g = \bar{f} \circ (\bar{c}_A \circ -) \quad (16)$$

Hence, with $(\bar{c}_A \circ -)$ being an epimorphism in $\mathbf{R-Mod}$ (because $\bar{c}_A$ is epimorphism in $\mathcal{A}'$, and $(\bar{P}, -)$ is exact), this enforces $\bar{f} = f \circ -$, showing the desired result. $\square$

3 Functor Category and Grothendieck Category

After establishing the special case, the next approach will be embedding Abelian categories into a category that's bicomplete and with projective generator (or dually, embedd into bicomplete category with injective cogenerator using contravariant embedding).

Here is a candidate:

Definition 10. Let $\mathcal{A}$ be a small Abelian category, $\mathbf{Ab}$ be the category of Abelian groups. Then, denote $(\mathcal{A}, \mathbf{Ab})$ as the category of all additive functors from $\mathcal{A}$ to $\mathbf{Ab}$, with the objects being these functors, and morphisms being natural transformations.

Of course, there are more to verify: Is it an Abelian category? Is it bicomplete? Does it have a projective generator?

Theorem 3. $(\mathcal{A}, \mathbf{Ab})$ is an Abelian category.

Proof. We'll construct half of the conditions, and the other half can be proven in similar manner using dual construction.

A0: Consider the zero functor $\bar{0}$, where $\bar{0}(A) = \mathbf{0}$ for all $A \in \mathcal{A}$, and $(f : A \rightarrow B) \mapsto (0 : \mathbf{0} \rightarrow \mathbf{0})$ for all morphism f in $\mathcal{A}$. Since $\mathbf{0}$ serves as a zero object in $\mathbf{Ab}$, then given any

A1: To verify finite biproduct exists, given $F_1, F_2 \in (\mathcal{A}, \mathbf{Ab})$, define $F_1 \oplus F_2(A) := F_1(A) \oplus F_2(A)$, and given morphism $f : A \rightarrow B$, a natural choice of morphism is $(F_1 \oplus F_2)(f) = \begin{pmatrix} F_1(f) & 0 \\ 0 & F_2(f) \end{pmatrix} : F_1(A) \oplus F_2(A) \rightarrow F_1(B) \oplus F_2(B)$.

Which, this is a functor, since given $f : A \rightarrow B$, $g : B \rightarrow C$, we have:

$$F_1 \oplus F_2(g \circ f) = \begin{pmatrix} F_1(g \circ f) & 0 \\ 0 & F_2(g \circ f) \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} F_1(g) \circ F_1(f) & 0 \\ 0 & F_2(g) \circ F_2(f) \end{pmatrix} \quad (17)$$

$$= \begin{pmatrix} F_1(g) & 0 \\ 0 & F_2(g) \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} F_1(f) & 0 \\ 0 & F_2(f) \end{pmatrix} = F_1 \oplus F_2(g) \circ F_1 \oplus F_2(f) \quad (18)$$

And, since both F_1, F_2 preserves direct sum, so:

$$F_1 \oplus F_2(A \oplus B) = F_1(A \oplus B) \oplus F_2(A \oplus B) \quad (19)$$

$$\cong (F_1(A) \oplus F_1(B)) \oplus (F_2(A) \oplus F_2(B)) \quad (20)$$

$$\cong (F_1(A) \oplus F_2(A)) \oplus (F_1(B) \oplus F_2(B)) \quad (21)$$

$$\cong (F_1 \oplus F_2(A)) \oplus (F_1 \oplus F_2(B)) \quad (22)$$

Hence, the functor $F_1 \oplus F_2$ preserves direct sum, which is also additive.

Finally, it serves as a biproduct (which we'll prove only for product, as coproduct applies with the same proof): Take $\pi_1 : F_1 \oplus F_2 \rightarrow F_1$ given by $\pi_{1,A} = (1_{F_1(A)} \ 0) : F_1 \oplus F_2(A) \rightarrow F_1(A)$ as the projection map of the $F_1(A) \oplus F_2(A)$ (similarly, $\pi_{2,A} = (0 \ 1_{F_2(A)}) : F_1 \oplus F_2(A) \rightarrow F_2(A)$). It forms a natural transformation, because given any morphism $f : A \rightarrow B$, we have the following commutative diagram:

$$\begin{array}{ccc}
F_1(A) \oplus F_2(A) & \xrightarrow{(1_{F(A)} \ 0)} & F_1(A) \\
F_1 \oplus F_2(f) \downarrow & & \downarrow F_1(f) \\
F_1(B) \oplus F_2(B) & \xrightarrow{(1_{F(B)} \ 0)} & F_1(B)
\end{array}$$

Due to the following computation:

$$\pi_{1,B} \circ (F_1 \oplus F_2(f)) = (1_B \ 0) \begin{pmatrix} F_1(f) & 0 \\ 0 & F_2(f) \end{pmatrix} = F_1(f) = F_1(f) \circ (1_{F(A)} \ 0) = F_1(f) \circ \pi_{1,A} \quad (23)$$

A2: Given

□